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Leveraging secondary associations to build brand equity: theoretical perspectives and practical applications

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ABSTRACT

One potentially valuable strategy for companies to build brand equity for their products and services is to actually link their brands to other people, places and things. By linking their brands to these other entities, consumers may change how they think, feel or act towards the company's brands. To help understand how these secondary associations can transform brand knowledge, a comprehensive, cohesive model of brand building – the brand resonance model – is reviewed and applied. Theoretical insights are generated and practical issues are identified and discussed to aid brand planning and measurement.

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Brands can build meaning with consumers in many different ways (Keller and Lehmann 2006; Schmitt 2012). Although a positive personal experience with a product or service is an invaluable way to establish strong, favorable and unique associations for a brand, marketing communications – in their broadest form – often play a critical role in brand building too. One important way that brands can build meaning through marketing communications is by using them to tap into or borrow meaning from another entity – another person (e.g., celebrity endorser), place (e.g., country of origin), or thing (e.g., a cause).

Leveraged marketing communications can be thought of in terms of leveraging secondary associations – “secondary” because they are associations linked to another entity that in some way changes the meaning of the brand for consumers (Bergkvist and Taylor 2016). In other words, consumer knowledge for a brand may be created or changed by linking it to some other person, place or thing with its own identifiable node and knowledge in memory that consumers feel conveys some relevant information or meaning about the brand (Keller 1993).

Brands thus may themselves be linked to other entities that have their own associations, creating “secondary” brand associations. Because the brand becomes identified with another entity, even though this linked entity may not directly relate to the product or service performance of the brand in any way, consumers may infer that the brand shares certain associations or meaning with that entity, thus producing indirect

or secondary associations for the brand. In essence, the marketer is borrowing or “leveraging” some associations and knowledge from the other entity to create or enhance some associations and knowledge to help to build its own brand equity.

There may be many different types of entities with which to be linked and, and as will be outlined below, many different types of associations which could potentially transfer. For example, the brand may be linked to certain source factors, such as the company, countries or other geographical regions, and channels of distribution, as well as to other brands, characters, spokespeople, sporting or cultural events, causes, or some other third party sources (through awards or reviews). All of these different entities could have a myriad of different kinds of associations of potential value to leverage.

As an example of some of the branding issues involved, assume Nike – the highly successful makers of shoes, clothing and equipment in a wide variety of sports – decided to introduce a new tennis racquet called, “The Avenger.” Although Nike sells tennis shoes and apparel, they have yet to introduce a tennis racquet. In creating the marketing program to build brand equity for the new Avenger racquet, Nike could attempt to leverage secondary brand knowledge in a number of different ways, as follows.

1. Nike could leverage associations to its corporate brand by “sub-branding” the product, e.g., by calling it the “Nike Avenger” or “The Avenger by Nike.” Consumer evaluations of the brand extension would be influenced by the extent to which consumers: a) held favorable associations about Nike as a company or brand because of their other athletic shoes, clothing and equipment; and b) felt that such knowledge was predictive of a tennis racquet that the company made.
2. Nike could try to sell through upscale, professional tennis shops and clubs in a hope that their credibility would “rub off” on the Avenger brand.
3. Nike could attempt to co-brand by identifying a strong ingredient brand for their grip, frame, or strings (e.g., as Wilson did by incorporating Goodyear tire rubber on the soles of their ProStaff Classic tennis shoes).
4. Nike could use one or more of its top professional players to also endorse or become an advertising spokesperson for the racquet (e.g., Rafael Nadal or Serena Williams), or they could choose to become a sponsor of select tennis tournaments or even the entire ATP men’s or WTA women’s professional tennis tour.
5. Nike could attempt to secure and publicize favorable ratings from third party sources (e.g., *Tennis* magazine).
6. Nike could try to rely on Oregon and its West Coast roots, although such a location would not seem to have any special relevance to tennis.

Thus, independent of the associations created by the racquet itself, its Avenger brand name, or any other aspects of the marketing program, Nike may be able to build equity by linking the brand to these other entities in these various ways. We next consider the nature of brand knowledge that marketers can attempt to transfer or leverage from other entities and the process by which marketers can try to do so.

Theoretical perspectives

In this section, we outline some basic considerations before delving into the details of a model application. Our assumption is that the target brand under study is a product or service brand. Even if it comes in the form of a corporate brand, it is assumed that products and services of some kind are its core and the foundation of its meaning.

Basic considerations

In general, two factors may be particularly important in predicting how much leverage might result from linking the brand to another entity:

1. *Nature of the knowledge about the linked entity* - If consumers have no familiarity with or knowledge of the other entity, then obviously there is nothing that can be transferred (John et al. 2006). Ideally, as will be developed below, consumers would be aware of the entity, hold some strong, favorable, and perhaps even unique associations towards the entity, have positive judgments and feelings about the entity, and have developed an intense, active loyalty relationship with it (Keller 2003).
2. *Impact of the knowledge about the linked entity* - Assuming that consumers have some potentially valuable knowledge about the other entity, to what extent is this knowledge evoked in the context of the brand? In what ways does it change knowledge about the brand? How does it change behavior towards the brand? Thus, a key issue is the extent to which knowledge about the linked entity will become positive – when considered *in the context of the brand* – such that consumers update their knowledge about the brand in some positive way and act more favorably towards it as a result.

In other words, the two crucial questions with transferring secondary knowledge from a linked entity to a product or service brand are: 1) What do consumers know about the linked entity; and 2) Does any of this knowledge affect what consumer think or feel about the brand and how they act towards it? Affirmative answers to the first question are the necessary, but not sufficient condition for affirmative answers to the second question. In other words, some knowledge about an entity has to exist before it can be inferred or transferred to the brand.

A number of issues come into play in understanding this two-step process and how the two factors might operate differently depending on the different types of entities and the different dimensions of knowledge potentially involved. We next turn to another model to help us with that analysis.

Nature of the knowledge

The brand resonance model describes how to create intense, active loyalty relationships with customers for a brand (Keller 2001; Keller and Swaminathan 2020). The model considers what consumers think, feel, and do and the degree to which they

Brand Resonance Pyramid

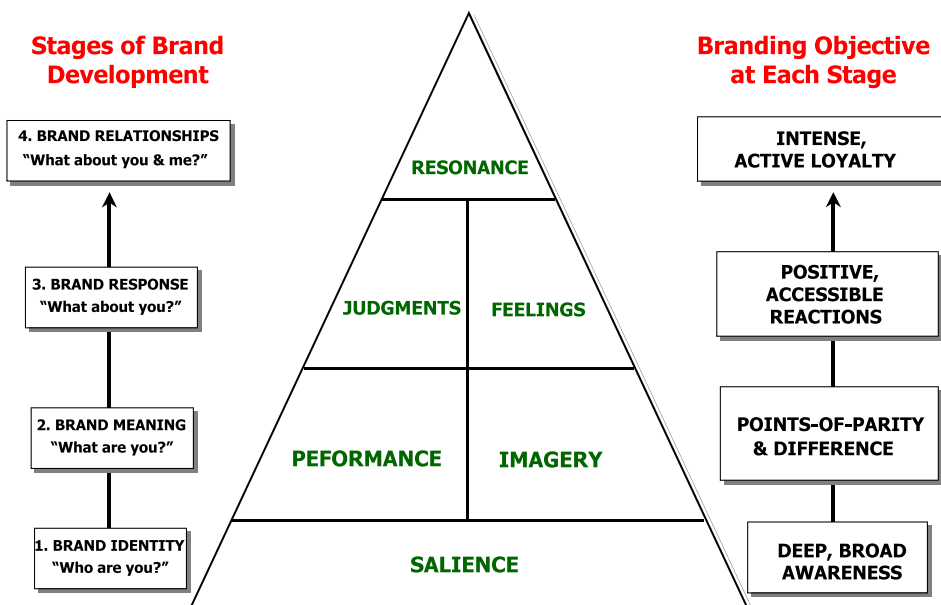


Figure 1. Brand resonance pyramid.

connect or "resonate" with a brand. Brand resonance is defined as the intensity of customers' psychological bond with the brand and the level of activity it engenders.

The brand resonance model views brand building as an ascending series of steps, from bottom to top, as: (1) ensuring customers identify the brand and associate it with a specific product class or set of needs; (2) firmly establishing the brand meaning in customers' minds by strategically linking a host of tangible and intangible brand associations; (3) eliciting the proper customer responses in terms of brand-related judgment and feelings; and (4) converting customers' brand responses to intense, active loyalty. Each step is contingent on successfully achieving the objectives of the previous one.

According to this model, enacting the four steps requires establishing a pyramid of six "brand building blocks" as illustrated in Figure 1, with stages of brand development and branding objective at each stage also shown. The model emphasizes the duality of brands—the rational route to brand building is on the left side of the pyramid and the emotional route is on the right side. Creating significant brand equity requires reaching the top of the brand pyramid, which occurs only if the proper building blocks are put into place.

- *Brand salience* is how easily and often and in what ways customers think of the brand under various purchase or consumption situations – the depth and breadth of brand awareness.
- *Brand performance* is how well the product or service meets customers' more functional needs.

Brand Resonance Pyramid Sub-Dimensions

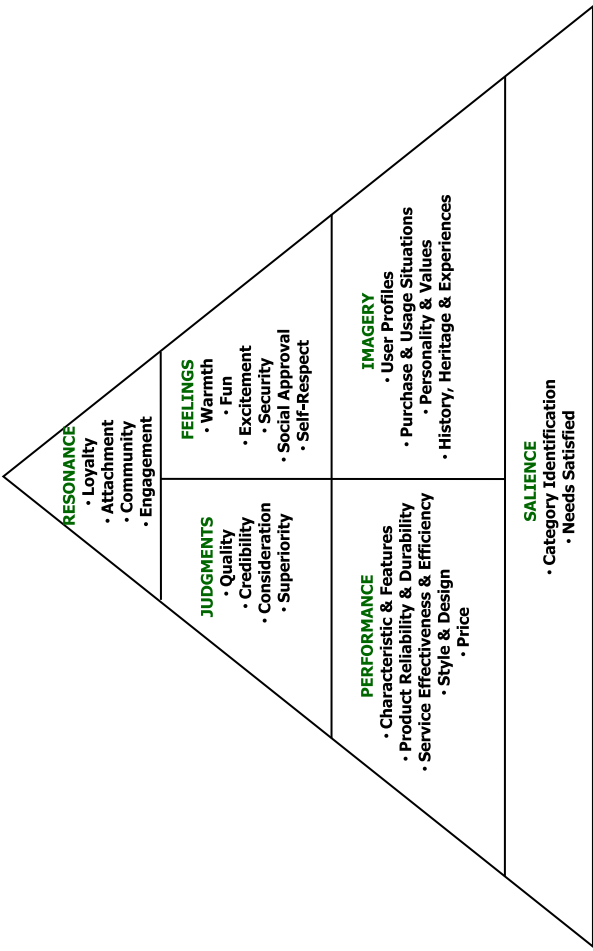


Figure 2. Sub-dimensions of brand resonance pyramid.

Brand Resonance Pyramids
as a Guide to Equity Transfer

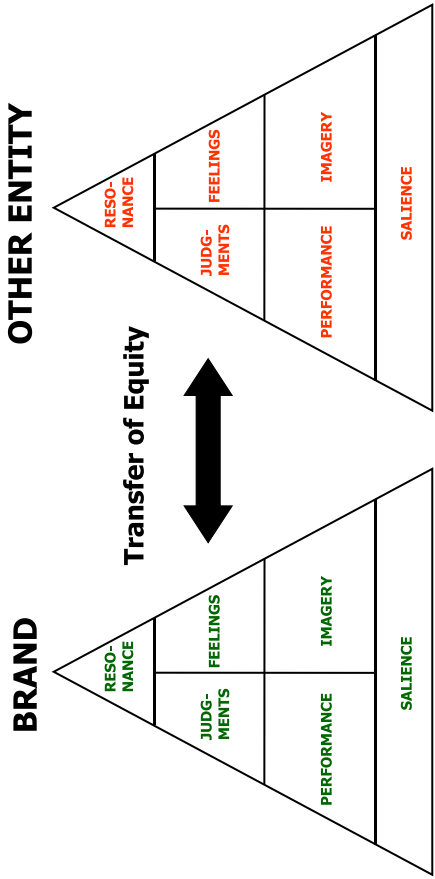


Figure 3. Brand resonance model as a guide to knowledge transfer.

- *Brand imagery* describes the extrinsic properties of the product or service, including the ways in which the brand attempts to meet customers' more psychological or social needs.
- *Brand judgments* focus on customers' own personal opinions and evaluations.
- *Brand feelings* are customers' emotional responses and reactions with respect to the brand.
- *Brand resonance* describes the relationship customers have with the brand and the extent to which they feel they're "in sync" with it.

Each of the six building blocks has a number of different sub-dimensions that provide richness and diagnostic insight (see [Figure 2](#)). As a whole, the brand resonance model provides a comprehensive, cohesive understanding of brand building in the marketplace, i.e., what consumers think and feel about a brand and how they act towards it.

Because it captures the full range of brand development – from a new brand just trying to establish itself in the marketplace to a mature brand seeking to deepen and broaden relationships with its current customer base – the brand resonance model is a helpful tool for understanding how brands at different stages of development can leverage secondary associations to build or maintain their brand equity.

In applying the brand resonance model to understand secondary associations, the key is to recognize that the linked entity can itself be viewed as a brand. It has a name and perhaps even other brand elements, and it may take on some – or even a lot of – meaning with consumers in the marketplace. As with a product or service brand, brand knowledge of the linked entity consist of all the thoughts, feelings, images, beliefs, experiences, behaviors etc. that a consumer stores in memory and associates with the linked entity.

The flexibility of the brand resonance model is that it applies equally well to any type of brand and thus any type of entity that can be thought of as a brand, e.g., a person, place or thing. The question then becomes, *how do the brand resonance pyramids of the brand and the other linked entity relate in the minds of consumers?* In particular, how does consumer knowledge of the brand – defined broadly in terms of the brand resonance pyramid – change as a result of the knowledge about the other entity (see [Figure 3](#)).

From a brand resonance model point of view, there are several considerations to keep in mind in understanding this transfer or updating process. Obviously, the more resonance that has been created for the other entity – and thus the corresponding salience, performance and imagery, and judgments and feelings that also exist – the more opportunity there is to have the target brand impacted by the linked entity. Moreover, in general, those transfer or leveraging effects are often likely to be "parallel" such that imagery associations for the linked entity are more likely to affect or create imagery associations for the product or service brand; feeling associations for the linked entity are more likely to affect or create feeling associations for the product or service brand; and so on.

Nevertheless, it is also possible that "halo effects" occur such that "crossover effects" prevail and one type of knowledge about the linked entity affects multiple

types of knowledge for the brand. For example, positive affect for a linked celebrity spokesperson or popular cause or event may not only create positive feelings or judgments towards the brand, it may also even color specific perceptions or beliefs about the brand's performance or imagery.

Beyond these general observations, more specific insights can come from considering each of the six building blocks, as follows.

Salience

Salience concerns how easily and often a brand is thought of and in what ways – is it thought of at all the right times, in all the right places and in all the right ways? Salience reflects the depth and breadth of brand awareness. Certainly by linking a brand to an entity that is better known, there may be an opportunity to increase the depth of brand awareness so that more people recall the brand more easily and more often. The breadth of brand awareness could also be enhanced if the association changes how – or at least when and where – consumers think of a brand, although that may be harder to have happen in general.

That is, given the linked entity, as a person, place or thing, is typically not directly related to the the product or service performance, it may be harder for its meaning to somehow change the way consumers think of when, where, and how the brand performs. Nevertheless, such broadening can happen. For example, assume an insurance brand wanted to be thought of more broadly as a “financial service brand” that helps consumers “establish a firm financial foundation.” By securing a well-known financial expert, supporting a financial literacy non-profit, and/or (especially) co-branding with another financial service brand, consumers may form new associations that increase the salience of the brand in other financial domains beyond insurance.

Performance

Performance describes how well the product or service meets customers' more functional needs. How well does the brand rate on objective assessments of quality? To what extent does the brand satisfy functional needs and wants and provide utilitarian, aesthetic, and economic benefits to customers in the product or service category? Five important types of attributes and benefits often underlie brand performance:

1. Primary ingredients and supplementary features
2. Product reliability, durability, and serviceability
3. Service effectiveness, efficiency, and empathy
4. Style and design
5. Price

Similar to the issues noted with breadth of awareness and salience, because performance relates so much to the actual functioning of the product or service, the meaning of other entities can often be more removed from how the brand works or performs and potentially be seen by consumers as less relevant. Nevertheless, as was

also noted above, even performance may be impacted by secondary associations. For example, linking to country of origin may change the fashionability of Italian suits, the taste of French wines, the driving performance of German automobiles, etc. In general, however, secondary associations are probably more likely to impact imagery than performance associations, as discussed next.

Imagery

Brand imagery depends on the extrinsic properties of the product or service, including the ways in which the brand attempts to meet customers' psychological or social needs. It is the way people think about a brand abstractly, rather than what they think the brand actually does. Thus, imagery refers to more intangible aspects of the brand. By its very definition, imagery is more dependent on extrinsic factors resulting from marketing communications and thus potentially leveraged entities.

Many kinds of intangibles can be linked to a brand, but four main ones are:

1. User profiles
2. Purchase and usage situations
3. Personality and values
4. History, heritage, and experiences

Leveraged entities offer much opportunity to add or change the imagery meaning for brands. By virtue of their human characteristics, linking a brand to a person, event, organization or can have the potential to affect personality, values and user imagery for the brand (Aaker 1997; Chernev, Hamilton, and Gal 2011; Mathur, Jain, and Maheswaran 2012).

Because many different entities are likely to have personality characteristics or values themselves, secondary associations from linked entities are particularly useful for establishing or enhancing personality dimensions for a brand. For example, if a brand wants to be seen as "fun and playful," it can use a comedic actor or actress in advertising and/or sponsor a comedy festival. If the brand wants to be seen as "sincere and competent," it can instead use a dramatic actor or actress, perhaps known for playing roles as a political leader or CEO and/or sponsor more civic-minded events or organizations.

Formally, Aaker (1997) examined 60 brands and found they fell into five main clusters or dimensions of brand personality: sincerity, excitement, competence, sophistication and ruggedness. Depending on the brand personality dimension(s) a brand aspires to embody, a brand can choose to align with entities that have the desired personality. In terms of brand these personality dimensions, some events, like the Ironman Triathlon in Hawaii, can be described as "rugged." Other sponsored events, like New York's Metropolitan Opera, are likely to be seen as "sophisticated." Still others, like NCAA "March Madness" post-season basketball tournament, are all about "excitement." As another example, charities such as the World Wildlife Fund would be considered to exhibit "sincerity." Along these lines, brands that aspire to personalities of ruggedness and/or excitement might be more likely to sponsor these types of

sporting events, whereas brands aspiring to personalities of sophistication and/or sincerity might be more likely to sponsor these types of arts organizations or causes.

Additionally, linked entities with experiential components, such as events, can also be expected to add experiences to a brand. For example, if a brand wants to be seen as more edgy and daring, it can sponsor action sports; if wants to be seen as more youthful and energetic, it can sponsor youth-oriented events and activities such as musical concerts or craft beer festivals; and so on. In general, linked entities offer the greatest potential to affect imagery associations in these and other different ways.

Judgments

Brand judgments are customers' personal opinions about and evaluations of the brand, which consumers form by putting together all the different brand performance and imagery associations. Customers may make all types of judgments with respect to a brand, but four types of judgments are particularly important for a brand: judgments about the quality, credibility, consideration, and superiority of the brand.

Although all four major types of judgments for the linked entity may affect brand knowledge, given its more abstract nature, credibility would seem like the one for the brand most likely to be directly affected by the linked entity. Brand credibility is the extent to which consumers believe that a firm can design and deliver products and services for a brand that satisfy customer needs and wants. Credibility itself has three dimensions – expertise, trust and likability. By associating with a highly credible entity known or seen as being expert, trustworthy and/or likable, there may more halo effects impacting the brand on those same dimensions.

Celebrities can exemplify one or more of these dimensions. The success of various celebrities such as Oprah Winfrey, George Clooney or Bono as a spokesperson is in large part due to the fact that they are viewed favorably by many on all three dimensions. As another approach, likeability can be enhanced by sponsoring events that consumers enjoy, because they may be more likely to feel positive about the brand as a result. Additionally, sponsoring a well-liked event may contribute to perceptions that the brand is more customer-oriented and can enhance trustworthiness.

Consideration and superiority may similarly benefit from the linked entity if it helps the brand to be seen as more relevant and differentiated. On the other hand, quality may be the least likely to be directly affected, depending on the performance implications of the linked entity, as noted above. Brand quality judgments are more likely to result from direct experience or usage of the brand. Nevertheless, a sponsored person or event may be able to contribute to perceptions of quality, for example, if the sponsorship can be used to showcase aspects of the brand that contributes to quality judgments.

Feelings

Brand feelings are customers' affective and emotional responses to the brand (Pham, Geuens, and De Pelsmaker 2013; Coleman and Williams 2013). Brand feelings also relate to the social currency evoked by the brand. What feelings are elicited by the marketing program for the brand or by other means? How does the brand affect

customers' feelings about themselves and their relationship with others? These feelings can be mild or intense and can be positive or negative. The brand resonance model highlights six important types of brand-building feelings.

1. Warmth
2. Fun
3. Excitement
4. Security
5. Social approval
6. Self-respect

These six feelings can be divided into two broad categories: The first three types of feelings are experiential and immediate, increasing in level of intensity; the latter three types of feelings are private and enduring, increasing in level of gravity.

There are many different types of feelings that may be established or accentuated for the brand as a result of a linked entity. By their very nature, events may be particularly effective with more experiential and immediate feelings. Still, sponsors can generate private and enduring feelings such as social approval, since consumers may attend an event such as a concert or a sports game to earn social approval and build social currency. Certain people may also be particularly effective as endorsers by evoking feelings of warmth, fun and excitement. In these and many other ways, secondary associations can have a significant effect on different brand-related feelings.

Resonance

Brand resonance focuses on the ultimate relationship and level of identification that the customer has with the brand and describes the extent to which customers feel that they are "in sync" with the brand. Resonance is characterized in terms of intensity, or the depth of the psychological bond that customers have with the brand (Thomson, MacInnis, and Park 2005), as well as the level of activity engendered by this loyalty (e.g., repeat purchase rates and the extent to which customers seek out brand information, events, and other loyal customers). These two dimensions of brand resonance can be broken down into four categories:

1. Behavioral loyalty
2. Attitudinal attachment
3. Sense of community
4. Active engagement

As with all of the other building blocks for brand resonance, linked entities could potentially impact any of these four categories. Attachment could occur as a result of direct affect transfer – affection and admiration for the linked entity may transfer directly to the brand. If, at the lower levels of the resonance pyramid, an association with another entity builds positive brand imagery, judgments and feelings, it may be more likely to elicit stronger attitudinal attachment. A sense of community could also

follow if the brand is able to tap into the community and fandom associated with a popular celebrity or event. For example, one of the selling points of NASCAR for years was that its fans felt part of a special community and supported any brands that sponsored NASCAR. Active engagement with the brand can also be established if the event sponsorship has experiential components, like product trials or demos, or if the sponsor plays a key role in bringing the event to the public and earns credit from consumers.

Behavioral loyalty is difficult to influence through the linkage to another entity alone, since consumers are typically not directly experiencing or using the brand as a result. It is possible to build behavioral loyalty, however, by extending the linkage the other entity. For example, if a marketer integrates its brand into an event, or builds a promotional campaign around the event that encourages product usage, these can yield opportunities to generate behavioral loyalty.

True brand resonance may be difficult to achieve as a direct consequence of sponsorship of a person or event or through the linkage of other entities. It typically occurs as the result of a series of direct, positive interactions with the brand. With a event sponsorship, for example, a sponsoring brand is rarely the focal point for the participant, which is why it is essential for sponsors to do more than simply sign a sponsorship deal. They must support and enhance the sponsorship with other marketing activities that occur outside the bounds of the event itself. Many sponsors do not take full advantage of their sponsorship programs by complementing them with robust external marketing to create more direct brand interactions.

In general, the more consumers feel an intense, active loyalty relationship with the linked entity, the more likely they might be to notice a brand affiliation. Although that realization could potentially lead to changes in knowledge for the brand, ultimately many of the other factors noted above would also come into play to determine how much brand awareness, image, response or relationships were affected.

Impact of the knowledge

The brand resonance model is particularly well-suited to address the first step in the leveraging process – understanding the breadth and depth of the knowledge that consumers have for both the linked entity and the brand itself. As outlined some above, it can also be helpful with the second step in the leveraging process and whether knowledge of the linked entity is deemed by consumers as potentially relevant and meaningful for the brand. In this section, we consider several additional issues related to that second step of the process, i.e., how brand knowledge and judgments and decision-making might actually change for consumers as a result of knowledge of the linked entity.

Effects on Brand knowledge

When consumers recognize that a brand is linked to another entity, they may implicitly or explicitly infer that some of the particular associations, judgments, or feelings that characterize the other entity may also characterize the brand. That is, by using communications in some form to make a connection between the brand and another entity, consumers may form a mental association from the brand to the linked entity

and, consequently, knowledge for that linked entity may therefore “transfer” in some form over to the brand.

Assuming some potentially relevant and meaningful knowledge exists for the linked entity, connecting the brand to that other entity may: 1) affect existing brand associations or 2) potentially create some new brand associations. The degree of transferability will depend, in part, on the intensity (how much people think about the other entity) and direction (how much of this thinking is also directed at the brand) of processing. This transfer can be either positive, if the knowledge being transferred is beneficial to the brand, or negative, if the knowledge is detrimental to the brand.

The meaningfulness of the knowledge about the linked entity may vary depending on the brand and product context. Some knowledge about the other entity may seem relevant and applicable to the brand, whereas other knowledge may seem to have little connection or importance. The inferencing process will depend largely on the strength of the relationship in consumers’ minds between the brand and other entity. The more consumers see similarity – of some kind – between the brand and the linked entity, the more likely it is that consumers will infer similar knowledge between the two. If the other entity is seen as wholly dissimilar and not sharing any features or connections, then consumers may be more likely to compartmentalize the two and not transfer any knowledge or associations.

If consumers do see some basis of similarity, in theory, essentially any aspect of knowledge may be inferred from other entities to the brand. In general, however, it may be more likely for higher level judgments or feelings to transfer from the entity than more specific lower level performance or imagery associations. Although possible exceptions were noted above, in general, many specific performance or even imagery associations about the linked entity may be more likely to be seen as irrelevant or too strongly connected to the original entity to transfer to the brand.

The transferability process is a function of other factors too beyond the fit between the brand and other entity. For example, transferability may depend on consumers’ level of engagement with different marketing activities associated with the other entity. Other brands linked to the other entity also may affect transferability, depending on how much of the other brand’s brand associations and activities are connected to the other entity.

Linking the brand to some other entity may not only affect existing brand knowledge, this linkage may also establish new knowledge about the brand. New brand knowledge may be created if the linked entity conveys meaning or elicits responses which do not currently exist for the brand. If consumers feel this meaning or responses are relevant for the brand too, they may become also linked as a result. These new associations may be particularly valuable to enrich the meaning of the brand and establish its positioning in important ways, as discussed further below.

Effects on consumer judgments and Decision-Making

There are two main ways by which a leveraged entity can affect judgments and choice for the brand, as suggested by the theorizing with respect to central vs. peripheral routes of persuasion (Petty and Cacioppo 1986) or System 1 vs. System 2 thinking (Kahneman 2011).

The more direct effect on consumer decision-making (akin to the central route or System 1 thinking) is when knowledge of the linked entity changes brand knowledge such that the actual inputs into decisions – specific attributes or benefits – are evaluated or weighted differently. In other words, *consumers just assess and use specific considerations for the brand differently because of the existence of the linked entity*. If the linked entity changes beliefs or weight for performance or imagery considerations, then consumer judgments and decisions can potentially change too as a result.

The indirect effect on consumer decision-making (akin to the peripheral route or System 2 thinking) is when knowledge of the linked entity – by itself – drives consumer decision-making. In other words, attributes or benefits are not evaluated nor weighted differently, *just the mere knowledge of the association with the other entity becomes a factor in making judgments or choice with respect to the brand*. In other words, consumers may adopt an affect referral decision rule that leads them to base brand judgments and opinions strictly or largely on their judgments and opinions of the other entity.

In general, this indirect effect on judgments and decision-making for the brand is most likely when consumers lack either the motivation or ability to evaluate more product-related concerns. In other words, when consumers either don't care much about choosing a particular brand or don't feel that they possess the knowledge to evaluate particular brands, they may be more likely to make brand decisions on the basis of such secondary considerations as how they think or feel about the celebrity endorsing it, other brands associated with it, etc.

In summary, the important consideration here is that there multiple routes by which secondary associations can either directly or indirectly influence consumer decision-making. The two routes are not mutually exclusive, and different routes may be used by different consumers or even by the same consumer at different times.

Conclusions

Companies can build or strengthen brand equity for their products and services by linking their brands to other entities – other people, places and things – and changing how consumers think, feel or act towards these brands in the process. To understand how these “secondary associations” can potentially transform brand knowledge, a well-established model of brand building, the brand resonance model, was applied, yielding a number of theoretical and managerial insights. We conclude by summarizing some practical applications that follow from our analysis and by highlighting some directions for future research.

Implications

In theory, any aspect of knowledge may be inferred from linked entities to the brand, although some types of entities are perhaps more likely to create or affect certain kinds of brand knowledge than would other types of entities. For example, as suggested above, events may be especially conducive to the creation of experiences; people may be especially effective for the elicitation of feelings; other brands may be especially well suited for establishing particular attributes and benefits; and so on. At

the same time, any one entity may be associated with multiple dimensions of knowledge, each of which may impact brand knowledge directly or indirectly.

For example, consider the effects on knowledge of linking a brand to a cause. Take Pampers, P&G's multi-billion dollar diaper brand positioned on the basis of "Caring for Baby's Development." Identification of Pampers with a particular cause (e.g., Autism Speaks) could have multiple effects on brand knowledge for consumers. A cause marketing program could build brand awareness via recall and recognition; enhance brand image in terms of attributes such as user imagery (e.g., kind and generous) and brand personality (e.g., sincere); evoke brand feelings (e.g., social approval and self-respect); establish brand attitudes (e.g., credibility judgments such as trustworthy and likable); and create brand experiences (e.g., through a sense of community and participation in cause-related activities).

Choosing which other entities to become associated with and what knowledge to try to leverage should be based on thoughtful, careful analysis. For example, a *secondary association audit* can be conducted which would: 1) characterize the knowledge structures of the brand and all other entities (people, places and things) currently or potentially linked to the brand; and 2) evaluate the other entities in terms of their actual or potential ability, respectively, to affect brand equity according to the two factors of knowledge and impact.

In the remainder of this section we consider how the brand resonance model and other concepts might be used to conduct such an audit and discuss some other planning and analysis issues in choosing other entities and leveraging secondary associations.

Characterizing knowledge about the Brand and linked entities

In terms of conducting a secondary association audit, a good start point would be a deep, rich understanding of consumer knowledge structures for the brand itself, as well as those for other entities. Given its comprehensive nature, using the brand resonance model to guide the audit increases the likelihood that the full range of possible leveraged effects are identified and explored. The resonance model could be used to profile knowledge for both the brand and all the currently linked entities, as well as potentially linked entities.

Profiling these brand knowledge structures should reveal critical sources of brand equity. In terms of the brand itself, what types of thoughts, feelings, images, perceptions, experiences, attitudes, and so on does the brand elicit? This understanding provides a point of reference by which the brand building contribution of linked entities and secondary associations can be interpreted. Comparing the two resonance models would then be helpful to understand what potentially might transfer. Specifically, secondary associations can then be critiqued on how much they might add or embellish brand awareness, enhance brand image, generate positive consumer judgments and feelings, and help to forge strong consumer bonds.

Assessing impact

Evaluating actual or potential impact, however, is more difficult. Survey work can be done based on test and control conditions with the other entity in question becoming

linked – or not – to the brand. Comparing the brand knowledge structures in the two conditions should yield some baseline insight into how the linked entity might change knowledge for the brand

In doing so, however, several points should be recognized. One, the actual marketing and communications program would undoubtedly highlight the linkage of the other entity in a much different way. The survey comparison would only provide a fairly limited view of what might actually happen in the marketplace. Two, the impact may not be all positive and some associations may weaken or become less favorable, and negative associations may actually be created. Recommendations would then center on how to maximize the desired and minimize the undesired equity transfer.

The most important consideration in evaluating other entities is how consumers perceive the relationship of the brand to the other entity. As noted above, the inferring process associated with leveraging secondary associations largely depends on the strength of the connection in consumers' minds between the brand and the other linked entity. The more consumers see similarity of the entity to the brand, the more likely it is that consumers will infer similar knowledge about the brand.

Entities may be chosen for which consumers have some or even a great deal of similar associations. A *commonality* leveraging strategy makes sense when consumers have associations in memory to another entity that are congruent with desired brand associations. For example, consider Dawn dish soap with its "tough on grease, but gentle on hands" positioning. By linking the brand to the cause of cleaning and rescuing birds affected by oil spills, Dove is able to reinforce its positioning and strengthen key brand associations of "strong" but "gentle."

On the other hand, there may be times that entities may be sought which represent a departure for the brand and where, by choice, there are few if any common or similar associations. Such *complementarity* leveraging strategies can be strategically critical in terms of delivering the desired position. For example, assume that Dawn dish soap was seen as strong but not gentle. Dove's cause marketing efforts to clean and rescue birds may be critical to actually even establish a "gentle" brand association.

As suggested by that example, leveraging is often designed to provide complementary brand knowledge in an attempt to shore up a negatively correlated attribute. As an actual real-world example, consider the comparatively youthful Matthew McConaughey endorsement of the aging Lincoln brand of automobiles to make it seem modern and contemporary. The challenge with a complementary strategy, however, is to ensure means of transferability such that the less congruent knowledge for the entity has either a direct or indirect effect on existing brand knowledge. This may require skillfully designed marketing programs that overcome initial consumer confusion or skepticism.

Even if consumers "buy into" the desired secondary associations one way or another, leveraging secondary brand knowledge may be risky because some control of the brand image is given up. The source factors or related person, place, or thing will undoubtedly have a host of other associations of which only some smaller set will be of interest to the marketer. Managing the transfer process so that only the relevant secondary knowledge becomes linked to the brand may be difficult. Moreover, this

knowledge may change over time as consumers learn more about the entity, and new associations, judgments, or feelings may or may not be advantageous for the brand.

Directions for future research

There are a whole host of research questions that the above analysis suggests. In general, additional research should examine both steps in our process model of leveraging secondary associations more closely. First, there needs to be a deeper, richer understanding of the knowledge structures typically associated with different types of entities. What differences commonly exist in consumer knowledge of different types of people, places and things? How might measures of brand resonance be adapted for different types of entities? Using the resonance model to compare and contrast knowledge of different types of entities can illuminate the potential types of secondary associations that may be leveraged by a brand.

Second, there also needs to be a better understanding of the leveraging process itself and how these different knowledge structures for other entities impact brand knowledge for products and services when linked. How easily are different types of associations or knowledge added or impacted? When are direct vs. indirect effects on judgments and choice likely to be manifested?

Multiple methods should be employed to explore both steps. For example, experimental and survey research can be used to profile consumer knowledge structures for different entities and how brand knowledge structures change as a result of a brand being linked to those entities; econometric analysis can be used to understand sales and market share shifts over time as a result of a brand being linked to different entities in different ways; From a more qualitative social and cultural point of view, CCT methods can be used to view how brands leverage secondary associations. In these and other ways, a more complete view can be achieved as to how marketing and communications can affect brand building by leveraging secondary associations.

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